DEFENDER GUIDE TO PERSONAL GROWTH

Bring your best self to all that you do and strengthen the gifts that make you, you

16Personalities

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Introduction

Why Personal Growth Matters for Defenders

Defenders – like everyone – want to bring their best selves to their daily lives. What sets Defenders apart is the diligence and care that they're willing to put into this effort. Hardworking and reliable, Defenders aren't particularly prone to flights of fancy. When they decide that they want to make improvements to themselves or their lives, they come up with a practical, achievable plan and they stick to it.

So *why* do Defenders care about personal growth? A great deal of their motivation comes from a desire to be there for other people. Defenders pride themselves on their ability to step in and help when others need them ¬– not just for tasks that will gain them a lot of praise or recognition but also for humble, behind-the-scenes efforts, such as cheering up a friend who's had a bad day or helping a nonprofit reorganize its offices. Defenders know that, by working on themselves and their own development, they can be more effective in their endeavors to help others.

Defenders are also motivated by an inner need for integrity – in other words, a desire to act in a way that matches their ideas and beliefs about the right thing to do in any situation. People with this personality type tend to be quite patient, but that doesn't mean they have patience for laziness or complacency – in themselves or in others. They want to make good use of their talents and abilities, not in the hopes of achieving renown or external rewards, but rather because acting in this way strikes them as the right thing to do. And for Defenders, doing the right thing is its own reward.

Strength in Stability

Everyone has gifts and strengths, and for Defenders, personal growth involves strengthening the gifts that make them who they are. Honing their practical skills and creating stability gets them up in the morning and defines their growth throughout their days. And thanks to their Observant and Judging traits, Defenders tend to have a strong ability to identify practical solutions and increase stability in their daily lives.

These types are most likely to experience growth when they discover ways to add structure to their lives and the lives of those they care about. This usually comes through hard work, attention to everyday details, and meeting obligations. When these contributions are kept in perspective, they prove valuable to their families, jobs, and communities, and their strengths provide Defenders with a robust and satisfying sense of self.

Growth through Challenges

However, nobody is perfect. Everybody has a little yin with their yang – a little weakness with their strengths. Personal development also involves addressing what blocks fulfillment and finding ways to compensate for weaknesses. For Defenders, finding balance against their tendency to overwork themselves – or their occasionally too rigid attitude – may come into play.

Learning to manage weaknesses is just as valuable as learning to develop strengths. Dealing with weakness often provides an opportunity to learn some of life's great lessons. To make it all work, Defenders may first need to develop flexibility and self-compassion. Recognizing and accepting any flaws that they find in themselves can lead to opportunities to address these weaknesses, potentially leading to growth, change, and improvement.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

Motivation and Development

There are five core motivating factors that drive Defenders' personal growth. These motivating factors involve Defenders seeing themselves in a particular manner or being a certain person.

For example, if they value being honest, they can value themselves more when they consistently tell the truth and approach life with a high measure of sincerity. If they feel they're floundering in the life, they may begin to speak the truth in an unnecessarily stark and brutal manner in a misguided (and sometimes not even conscious) attempt to emphasize that they're honest people. This exaggerated honesty may temporarily allow them to feel valued or righteous, but it's likely to lead them to an undesirable place in the end. Being "unbalanced" usually involves relying on traits and values in an extreme fashion. Normally commendable traits are unbalanced just because they're applied too generously, and consequently, things go off-kilter.

Defenders can consider personal growth in five closely related, but distinct, areas. The first three relate to the internal development of self-regard, and the latter two are more about tactics to engage more fulfilling lives.

Motivation

- **Self-esteem** speaks to how much they like themselves. Accepting both their flaws and strengths creates a base of internal appreciation that enables change motivated by desire instead of shame.
- **Self-respect** speaks to how much Defenders value themselves – it's their perception of their worthiness. When they live their beliefs and values, a balanced sense of pride in who they are follows.
- **Self-confidence** is the energy source that moves Defenders forward in life. When belief in their abilities is confirmed using their skills, Defenders are driven to make steady progress.

Development

- **Self-evolution** describes the process of personal growth that Defenders need to fully develop their potential. Knowing when to assess and expand themselves enhances their abilities and happiness.

- **Self-responsibility** is the ability to take charge of their decisions and the resulting consequences. Being conscious of their behavior and direction in life helps them guide their own progress instead of letting fate dictate a path.

Conscious personal growth is about more than feeling obligated to change. When inspired, these types to seek new ways to be happier and more successful – including an independent and personal definition of success. The goal is to spur their inner drive with ideas, encouragement, and gentle guidance for possible problems along the way.

Moving Forward

In the following sections, we'll first examine Defenders' characteristics in their most beneficial forms. Using these motivational components in "balanced" ways helps Defenders lead fulfilling, productive, and happy lives.

Next, we'll describe "unbalanced" tendencies that can emerge – departures from healthy, productive motivation strategies. We'll also explain some adverse effects Defenders may experience as a result.

Finally, we'll discuss what Defenders can do to improve or "rebalance" each of the motivational components, and provide exercises, reflection, and actions to aid in personal growth and development.

Self-Esteem

Balanced Self-Esteem

Defenders tend to never actively demand esteem from others. Doing so makes little sense to them because it's not part of their primary motivation. They see all they do as an expected duty. For them, it would be like celebrating that they brushed their teeth in the morning. It's just what should be done. When others appreciate them, Defenders feel stronger, even if it's presented in quieter ways. While Defenders may humbly protest when others try to show appreciation for their diligence, it likely pleases them – they just don't need a brass band. A simple "thank you, well done" will do.

Finding Way to Celebrate Victories

While having others' appreciation and approval is gratifying, their only guaranteed source is from within. Defenders may find they need to develop or be their own cheering section. This can be done in a variety of ways depending on personal preferences. If introspection is preferred, they might list their accomplishments or keep a journal, reviewing their challenges and victories daily. Or, if a demonstration of appreciation is in order, many people set goals and then reward themselves in some small way – Defenders might treat themselves to a local concert after a report is completed, for example.

If these types need a more social context (as even Introverts sometimes do), they may enlist others with whom they can share a mutual "brag" session. Defenders' willing spouses, family members, and friends can be natural partners to help recognize their contributions and accomplishments. Turning this into a dinnertime ritual with treasured natural or extended families may more than satisfy the need for outside validation, and, "What was your day like?" is likely to assume more weight than just a conversational nicety around Defenders' table.

Unbalanced Self-Esteem

When Duty Still Needs a Reward

While the amount of esteem one gets might sound like a vain concern, it can go deeper. Without some veneration and appreciation, people may forget they belong or have a purpose. Motivation ideally comes from within, but humans are social animals, and unsung heroes may appear noble while they secretly crave someone noticing.

Defenders who don't receive recognition for their work may imagine others don't care about what they contribute. They may suspect that someone is taking advantage of them, or that they aren't a vital part of a group. Since Defenders don't typically like to confront others, they may allow these thoughts to fester. None of these negative ideas foster a sense of belonging. They're likely to drain energy and enthusiasm.

Artificially Proving Importance

Defenders may also try to cope ineffectively using one or both of two methods: artificially proving their importance, and the passive-aggressive approach.

The first is establishing their importance, which can take a wrong turn when it feels forced, and care isn't taken to soften it. Picture the TV sitcom where a stereotypical bureaucrat behind the counter at the DMV won't cut a customer a break under any circumstances, or even take the time to hear them out. The hidden message is, "See, I'm important enough to belong here." On TV, they exaggerate these situations for laughs. Milder, more realistic versions might seep into the everyday life of even the most affable Defenders if they feel they aren't getting the esteem they deserve.

The Passive-Aggressive Approach

Passive-aggressive behavior is striking out at others by not doing what's expected as an alternative to a direct assault. Imagine Defenders who typically make beautiful breakfasts every day suddenly present undercooked eggs with blackened toast. Their hidden message to the eaters is, "Now you'll pay attention when I do it well." (These Defender cooks, by the way, may not even do this consciously – their resentment is sometimes so buried in their subconscious that it surprises them as well!)

People usually find ways to feel valued – even if they must do so in maladaptive ways. If Defenders try to force others in passive-aggressive ways to appreciate them, it often comes across as demanding and abrasive. Finding a more organic means of accomplishing the same thing can create pleasant experiences and help cement respectful relationships.

Rebalancing Self-Esteem

Self-Promotion and the Basic Need for Appreciation

A sense of belonging is a basic human need, and Defenders are notoriously weak at self-promotion. Their Introverted qualities can

cause them to easily fade into the background if they aren't careful. Some people are naturals at self-promotion, and some people are not. To rectify this, "self-promotion for Introverts" is now a hot topic on the Internet.

For some people, self-promotion can be thought of as a stress management technique, since it helps individuals relax more into their lives and feel more comfortable in their skins. Instead of experiencing the stress of feeling left behind when Extraverts hog all the glory, Defenders and other Introverts can explore strategies for getting the appreciation they deserve. This can help them get ahead and feel like a vital part of any group to which they belong.

Self-Promotion: Relating to Ourselves and Others

At first, Defenders may want to practice self-promotion on themselves. Taking an internal inventory of their value can be the first step to gaining the confidence needed to shine publicly. Even if self-promotion goes no further, Defenders can assure themselves of their worth and contributions to the world at large.

Their insular tendencies may cause them to fade into the wallpaper, but these types still value relationships. If they can think of self-promotion as part of building relationships, they might find it easier to tell others who they are and what they do. This perspective may feel less like they're "blowing their own horn" and more like they're sharing themselves openly with others.

The Elevator Pitch

Lastly, there's the old reliable "elevator pitch": the 30-second speech (the span of the typical elevator ride) that sums up and "sells" who we are. It's a way to self-brand and gets others to pay healthy attention. It doesn't have to be confined to professional use. Here's a real-life example of how Defenders can use this to introduce themselves comfortably.

- Bobby's Defender dad might present himself to Bobby's fifth-grade teacher – and other parents at the PTA meeting – in the following fashion: "I'm Bobby's father, chauffeur, knee-scrape doctor, and home study hall supervisor. While he depends on his mom to help him with daily homework, I'm around for his larger projects. So, if

the diorama doesn't cut it, you can blame Bobby, but my hand was involved in the crime as well."

- Obviously, running around a room repeating this can sound odd, so variations on a theme are acceptable and perhaps preferred.
- This breezy yet defining description of what Bobby's dad does for him is slightly self-effacing for those who are more comfortable being humble.
- Bobby's father may have a work version of this "elevator pitch," or even a golf course version. It's like a commercial slogan that repeats the speakers' attributes and gives others a chance to know them and their role in the group. It can be very effective at bringing someone who is usually in the background more to the forefront.

Self-Respect

Whether at home, at a job, or out in the community, Defenders who do the work that makes their self-respect healthy are likely to be a stabilizing force that others count on. Their effort to preserve a high level of self-respect plays out through daily, measurable diligence, and the people in their lives reap the benefits of Defenders' determination to be reliable.

Balanced Self-Respect

Defining Worth by Reliability

Self-respect is the self-measure of one's worth, and, for Defenders, they find their value in the degree of security they bring through the efficient and thorough execution of their tasks. While they appreciate praise and avoid others' judgment just like anyone else, they aren't their core motivations. These types need to satisfy themselves with the knowledge that they've done their duty. Most personality types feel a sense of contentment when they're where they should be and doing what they should be doing, but it isn't likely to be on the top of their list of the characteristics that define them, but it is for Defenders.

Reliably Faithful

A by-product of reliability is loyalty, so it follows that Defenders also attach this to their sense of self-worth. They're proud of their faithfulness to both individuals or organizations, and it's integral to their character. They strive to reliably complete tasks with the added understanding that doing so bolsters others. Loyalty and reliability aren't casually connected in the Defenders' minds. They're essentially linked.

With proven loyalty comes trust. With trust comes more responsibility. With more responsibility often comes more reward. While others may not always reward Defenders' loyalty, faithful individuals are more likely than unfaithful ones to have others' respect. Of course, there are no guarantees, and real life is often unfair. But Defenders' loyalty can position them for a fulfilling life of achievement.

Unbalanced Self-Respect

When Reliability Overheats

Acting reliably discourages surprises and chaos, and such predictability speaks to Defenders' Judging trait. However, life itself is unpredictable. Success often depends on flexibility, and this may mean abandoning preconceived notions of the way things "should be." However, it's the "should be" outlook that helps Defenders keep the sometimes-messy world in check.

When Defenders feel a loss of self-respect, they're likely to overcompensate by trying to hold everything in place with an unwillingness to be more elastic in their thoughts and behaviors. This can make them reject necessary changes, improvisations, and innovations. While their motivation to uphold constancy is laudable, if they become too rigid, this rigidity can turn into a judgmental and critical stance, which is rarely helpful.

Blind Loyalty

Loyalty is the by-product of self-respect, and these types may deal with flagging self-worth by clinging blindly to people, organizations, or cultural standards to keep any disruptive influences away. Nonetheless, blind loyalty is fraught with dangers.

Giving up too much personal control to honor commitments can lead to unintended poor results, which might include suspending Defenders' good judgment in favor of others, or letting unscrupulous leaders take advantage of them. Defenders are among the least likely to support the bumper sticker that advises: "Question Authority." At times, however, this admonition may be the difference between doing the right thing and not doing it. This can be good advice when Defenders are in the throes of self-doubt about their worth, as they may be vulnerable.

Rebalancing Self-Respect

Learning to Bend

The first step in dealing with a need for reliability as a cure for poor self-respect is for Defenders to find wholesome ways to reassure themselves of their dutiful, consistent natures. An inventory of the many ways they follow through on tasks and keep their worlds stable can help them gain the perspective they need. It's likely there's enough in their lives that, if listed, would reassure them of their purpose and their worth.

They can then begin to let go of rigidity enough to be more efficient. They may recognize that they're doing an excellent service already and that their value is nearly self-evident. They can feel good about whom they are and what they contribute.

Conscious Loyalty

Blind loyalty rejects questioning, so the cure for it is simple: ask questions. Defenders may wrongly assume that questioning the behavior of superiors or trusted organizations is disloyal. However, they don't necessarily have to respond to the answers they get, and can even keep the answers to themselves. There's no reason to share them – unless there is one. Should Defenders begin to worry about blind loyalty, the first step is to understand that questioning isn't inherently disrespectful, disruptive, or dangerous.

Here are some steps Defenders who feel bound too tightly to other people, organizations, or ideas may want to consider when separating their own thoughts on issues.

- Making a two-column chart with other's opinions or standards in one, and their thoughts in the other, can help them separate the two. (It may be easiest to start the chart listing the items on which they agree and seeing where it goes from there.)
- Throughout the process, Defenders may want to remind themselves that it's reasonable for them to hold their unique opinions.
- As with the first step, no action is necessary unless the Defenders feel there's something to address. To borrow an overworked cliché, knowledge is power, and is often all that's needed to begin resolving imbalances in life.

Self-Confidence

The Feeling trait is the foundation for the way Defenders make decisions that support their primary role of nurturer. It fosters their sincere desire to see those who are important to them being safe, happy, and prosperous in the world. They mold their lives around decisions made from the heart, and when these decisions see positive results, it bolsters Defenders' self-confidence. As is often the case with those who share the Feeling trait, Defenders value harmony, and this also influences their self-confidence.

Balanced Self-Confidence

Practical Organizing from the Heart

Like a three-legged stool, Defenders' practical combination of Observant and Judging traits, along with the Feeling trait, help them meet their harmonious goals. Bringing real-time order and stability to the people they care about is their version of nurturing. The welfare of the people in their lives provides their motivation and informs their choices. These types can be counted on to always be there when they're needed.

Because of their Observant traits, Defenders connect with the physical world, which allows them to readily pick up the cues of those around them and respond accordingly. Their attentive, responsive natures lead people to regard Defenders as nurturing individuals. They fall naturally into the roles of "parent," "giving friend," "understanding spouse,"

"nurse," "teacher," "support staff member," or even "caring manager at work." They're often among the first to notice signs of distress or discomfort, and express their personality by deciding how to ease those problems. Defenders are imaginative problem-solvers when the problems are practical, and their solutions are characteristically useful.

Unbalanced Self-Confidence

Too Little Tough Love

Conflict gets bad press among those who share the Feeling trait. Nonetheless, it can be helpful under the right circumstances. Defenders may be noble in their attempts to produce harmony, but there are legitimate needs for "tough love" on occasion. The word "enabler" may have been overused in recent decades, but Defenders tend to assume this role when they place their desire for harmony above the need to resolve difficult problems. Problems get worse when people fear "rocking the boat" more than being afraid of a damaged boat sinking. To avoid conflict, Defenders may instead repress unpleasant feelings like anger or sadness, leaving the problems that caused these emotions to remain unresolved.

"Over-Loving"

Just as too much conflict aversion can become enabling, too much nurturing can become coddling. For example, Defender parents may want to be alert in case their attention to their children becomes "over-loving" them, which is also known as "spoiling." However, indulging others beyond reason isn't just confined to parent-child relationships, and can be something Defenders need to guard against. It may be tempting for these types to "fix" things for those they love when real nurturing should involve lending support while their loved ones fix their problems themselves.

Hurt Feelings: The Other Side of Sensitivity

The sensitivity that makes Defenders so aware of the needs of others can also work against them if they're feeling the least bit insecure. They can be too sensitive to even the mildest slight. The subtlest dismissive gesture from a loved one may begin to feel like an overwhelming slam,

leading to their exclaiming, "I work so hard to take care of them, and this is how they treat me?" Taken a step further, when someone blatantly criticizes Defenders, it can devastate these sensitive souls.

Rebalancing Self-Confidence

Confident Defenders

Defenders tend to become so attached to the idea of harmony that they'll do anything to preserve it – leading to conflict avoidance and challenging problems remaining unsolved. So, how can these types become unstuck?

Fortunately, there are ways to deal with conflict that avoid aggression. Assertive behavior sits at the midpoint between passive and aggressive behavior, offers a method for standing up for oneself while avoiding hostility, and is something anyone can learn.

One of the assertiveness techniques that might prove helpful for Defenders is a reliance on "I feel..." statements. Coming at others using an accusatory "You..." statement puts them in a defensive position, often leading to fights. For Defenders who aren't comfortable with statements that feel aggressive, using a statement which explains how things are affecting them emotionally can seem less hostile to others. After all, it's hard to start a fight based on someone else's feelings. Here's an example of how Defenders can try this.

- For example, instead of saying, "I work cleaning this house all day. Then you come in, just throw your stuff everywhere, and leave it there until I pick it up," they might try, "I feel like you don't care about the time and work I put into cleaning the house when you don't put your stuff away."
- The first approach is accusatory and sets up a conflict that may lead to a fight. However, the second allows Defenders to express how the actions affect them and reflect their emotional state.
- Not only might such an approach be more palatable to harmony-loving Defenders, but it also allows them to bring difficult subjects to the surface more quickly. This gives both parties a better chance of resolving problems.

Self-Evolution

If everything were in a constant state of change, life would become messy. Defenders are the self-appointed champions of cultural traditions and accepted standards because they speak to their love of order and predictability, and serve to foster stability. Protocols are reliable like the Defenders themselves. But change is important and inevitable, and mature Defenders know when to adapt. While constants and points of references must be held in place to prevent chaos, Defenders can only self-evolve when they accept that they, too, must roll with the changes that are so much a part of everyday life.

Balanced Self-Evolution

The Guardians of Continuity

Defenders' home lives are likely to be traditional, where they can relish in practicing their accepted values and norms. At the workplace or in school, they often find themselves aligning with the procedures and expectations of these institutions. Defenders know the rules and not only obey them, but when someone ignores the decrees, they defend and enforce them. As Feeling Introverts, it may not be in caring Defenders' fundamental nature to take on rule-breakers, but order may mean enough to them that they do. Stability is the Defenders' superpower, and they tend to protect it.

Without a doubt, like a love song from yesteryear or a meal that conjures pleasant memories, there's a sense of comfort in the familiar. Defenders exude a perpetual sense of "home" that can be literal or a metaphor for some form of reliability. Defenders protect "what always has been" and provide society with a sense of healthy continuity. Because of people like Defenders, society is a lot more predictable and steady.

Unbalanced Self-Evolution

The Challenge of Change

As practical traditionalists, Defenders are among those people would call "the salt of the Earth." Being the salt of the Earth, however, doesn't mean they own the planet. Clinging to old ideas – even as things rapidly change – can produce a hard shell of intolerance if these types

can't balance established standards with change. It may be difficult for Defenders to observe changing morals, evolving methods, and a disregard for traditional standards and not cast severe judgment in their direction. Some may perpetually pit the old against the new rather than adapt.

Change is difficult for everybody, but Defenders and other Sentinels are the hardest hit when drastic shifts occur. Some Defenders may reject change consistently, and in the 21st century, they can undoubtedly be socially or professionally handicapped. What was once Defenders' fostering of traditional standards can become rigidity. What was a mastery of steadiness and stability can devolve into stubbornness.

Intolerance

Hate isn't a natural part of Defenders' character by any measure. Any intolerance they experience toward others is likely to be the product of fear more than disdain. If they associate a person or a group of "others" with undermining the traditional standards they fight to uphold, they may regard them as enemies. This can, paradoxically, disturb the harmony they labor so hard to create.

Rebalancing Self-Evolution

Tradition as a Guide

W. Somerset Maugham said, "Tradition is a guide and not a jailer," which can serve as a powerful insight for Defenders. When using it as a guide, Defenders don't diminish tradition, but they also don't enslave themselves to it, either. To restore balance against excessive rigidity and intolerance, it may be crucial to put tradition in a more realistic perspective.

Accepting the inevitability of change can be the first step. Learning to blend the old with the new may help Defenders create a more balanced view. Spotting the difference between maintaining stability and being stubborn can also help these types navigate the changing world better. Self-examination can be useful here. "Am I offering helpful insights into how things work, or am I just finding change difficult to handle?" Asking this and similar questions may help Defenders see change for the opportunity it is.

Reconsidering the Change Agents

Intolerance is an attitude, and there's little that combats it apart from changing one's position. How many good people or innovative ideas are left behind because of intolerance? It may help Defenders who face this problem to think in terms of efficiency rather than constancy. Here's some examples of how Defenders can adjust their attitude.

- "Reframing" is deciding to look at something from a different perspective. For example, instead of finding individuals threatening, what if instead Defenders try to reframe their perception, and the word "interesting" was applied instead of "threatening"?
- Making it a point to look for the positive during change, or a departure from that which Defenders already know, can make the experience less dire and threatening.
- Searching for the silver lining – and how it applies personally to Defenders' own goals and interests – can make change easier for them. It may even surprise them how much change works in their favor!

Self-Responsibility

Thomas Edison said, "The three great essentials to achieve anything worthwhile are: first, hard work; second, stick-to-itiveness; third, common sense" – and this serves as a mantra for most Defenders. While not all are entirely successful at fulfilling these goals, Defenders believe it is their responsibility to strive to realize these qualities.

Balanced Self-Responsibility

A Drive to Achieve

Whether at home or work, Defenders regard their efforts to organize and accomplish things as callings they must answer. They're likely to view themselves as at least partially responsible for any successes or failures that swirl through their lives. Work and home stir a deep sense of loyalty in these individuals. The label "Defender" is no mistake. Their commitment to their families, communities, and work groups encourages their responsible approach, as does their self-perception of being protectors.

The Gift of Persistence

Defenders enjoy the gifts of patience and focus. They're valiant in their ability to push through, even at some personal sacrifice. The most mundane work is no problem for Defenders if they grasp its purpose or if it's paired with a strong sense of obligation. These types would rather work overtime and lose sleep than turn in shoddy or incomplete work. Where others might dream longingly of their next vacation when work becomes too routine, Defenders see it as necessary, tolerating the repetitive better than most. They recognize the value of their efforts.

Masters of Logistics

Organization tends to come naturally to Defenders. If a package must be in New York by tomorrow, left up to these types, it will arrive the evening before. They know what to do and who to call to make things happen smoothly. At home and as parents, they're likely to have just as much of a command of resources.

Unbalanced Self-Responsibility

Too Much Responsibility, Too Little Self-Care

Personal and professional growth occurs when Defenders use their sense of responsibility and dedication to move forward in life. However, as with all good things, diligence can shift from a powerful tool to a demanding tyrant if not properly balanced against other considerations.

Defenders' self-esteem and confidence are built upon their successful execution of duties. When they aren't feeling great about themselves or their lives, their sense of responsibility may "overheat" in search of a positive sense of themselves. Instead of integrating self-care and rest into their lives, they may push relentlessly to feel that sense of responsible accomplishment.

Without taking time for themselves and finding some way to relax, Defenders are likely to experience burnout, exhausting themselves and losing their zeal for things that usually excite them. It makes them lose motivation. When this happens, they can find it hard to get out of bed in the morning or carry out even the most routine activities.

Suffering in Silence

Defenders' powerful sense of responsibility may not only add too much to their schedules and sap their energy, but it may also lead them to believe they're solely answerable for fulfilling the duties they're associated with. With their Introverted and Feeling traits constantly whispering warnings about making waves, Defenders may not even consider asking for help – even if asking wouldn't necessarily cause conflict. Extreme self-reliance can become almost reflexive for these types. Rather than risk raising the dust with a request for help, they may tell themselves something like, "It's less bother if I just do it myself."

Once Defenders pile on the responsibilities without delegating a few, they feel there's nowhere to vent when it becomes overwhelming. They're duty-bound individuals who may see any complaining as something akin to whining. This makes letting off harmful steam distasteful for them, adding to Defenders' tendency to repress emotions in favor of keeping the peace.

When Burnout Burns Others

While it's bad enough that burnout can affect Defenders, it can also spill over into their relationships. While they think they're pleasing the boss, the boss may see them instead as worn-out employees who may not be working as efficiently as they should, despite their over-the-top efforts. Those who burn out typically have short fuses. Excessive stress has damaged many a home. In the end, by not dealing with stress, Defenders may harm the very people they intend to look after.

The health implications and long-term consequences of stress are well known and easy to research on the Internet. Defenders who don't deal with stress may find their capacity to take care of others becomes limited in the future.

Rebalancing Self-Responsibility

Assessing Whether the Stress Worth Is Worth It

Defenders who find themselves suffering from responsibility overload may need to take some active measures to remedy any related

problems. For example, they might want to decide if their relentless efforts are paying off or not. Working exceedingly hard may indeed be the appropriate thing to do at times, but it can also exact a toll on these types. Matching the cost to the benefit is essential. It's counterproductive for Defenders to assume that strenuous work is the solution to everything.

Defenders typically choose action over ruminating over things. The action doesn't necessarily have to be bold. It could be as simple as tying up a loose end or attending to minute details that need completing. This approach can be an incredible asset for productive people. However, learning to *prioritize* what's important – and balancing it with self-care – can make Defenders' vigorously exerting themselves a more reasonable approach. Asking, "Why?" a bit more can help set a clearer path – especially when Defenders' need to feel responsible begins to overheat.

Stress Management for Those Who Roll Their Eyes at the Idea

"We must have a pie. Stress can't exist in the presence of a pie," wrote playwright David Mamet. Stress management is about finding a cozy, sheltered "kitchen" in one's life where stress isn't invited and baking a "pie," allowing Defenders to restore balance and their sense of being strong and whole, rather than beaten up and torn down.

To gain credibility with Defenders, it may be important to note that "stress management" isn't called "stress elimination." Stress, when balanced, has its place, and Defenders are that unique personality type who knows where reasonable tension fits into their lives, keeping them alert and motivated. It's only problematic when stressors are the only game pieces on the board, and no other choices are available. For them, it's something to manage but not necessarily sidestep.

Often, hardworking people like Defenders roll their eyes at the concept of stress management courses, but stress management is about becoming more productive. It should streamline actions and use of energy by finding some "pie" to balance their diligence with some relaxation and even pleasure. A thorough stress management course not only teaches how to deal with stress in the moment. It can also help Defenders plan their days, weeks, months, even their entire lives, in

ways that allow them to pace themselves better. (Interested Defenders can find stress management material online, and human resources departments at many companies offer such training.)

However, Defenders need to first recognize when their plate is too full. When is it all too much? It's different for everyone, even within the same personality types, as several factors affect stamina and motivation. Visible signs are exhaustion, quick tempers, or anxious feelings of dread becoming routine. Some Defenders who are overextended may lose a sense of joy in their lives, and even find themselves physically ill more often. Because of this, Defenders may need to learn to say the hardest word for them to utter – "No."

However, Defenders' default when stressed tends to be to do more. They busily look for things they can do to make things better, and then just do more. Doing more isn't always the answer. Even though it may feel positive, there's no inherent merit in always saying "yes." Much depends on the specific request and the surrounding situation.

Here are some ways Defenders who perceive life as trudging laboriously forward, can learn to say "no" and take that first step toward lightening their load.

- Any time Defenders decline participation, they typically handle it with respect. Nonetheless, they may want to double check that they're safeguarding the feelings of others to the extent it's possible. (However, this has limits. People feel what they feel regardless, and Defenders aren't always responsible for accommodating other's emotions. Emotional manipulation, conscious or not, shouldn't keep these types from responding with a proper "no.")
- Giving a reason for turning down a request is helpful if it doesn't turn into an excuse. Long, involved explanations aren't necessary, and instead muddy the waters. As a rule, brevity and honesty are essential to a clean "no."
- Obviously, how to say "no" is situational. Denying the request of a boss may be impossible in many workplaces where things aren't voluntary or optional. However, with most spouses, relatives, neighbors, and some bosses, there may be more latitude.

- When the only realistic solution ends up involving "doing more," Defenders can benefit from learning to delegate. These universal helpers find their lives improve if they share the wealth with others and ask those in their lives to help them in return. A substantial step in Defenders' stress management includes admitting they don't have to do it all.

When they do feel overwhelmed, having space to drop their emotional baggage can be most helpful. Spending some time writing out their concerns and their reactions, or talking to supportive friends or spouses, can be steps in the right direction. For some Defenders, it may take thinking about venting as something that's useful and not just self-indulgence – although there's nothing wrong with indulging themselves.

In the physical world, pressure seeks a release if it starts to become too much. It's better to bring about a release gradually rather than risk an explosion. Think of a pressure cooker. In the emotional world, the idea is the same. Finding ways to release stress slowly, in controlled and safe ways, can help Defenders ease the pressure.

Final Words

Exploring New Terrain

Like a seedling poking its head through the soil in the early spring, growth rarely happens without something emerging from the comforts of the familiar. Personal growth takes effort, and it may require Defenders to venture into new terrain that isn't always familiar or comfortable. But Defenders are steadfast and persistent, unlikely to be deterred by either hard work or discomforts as they strive toward their goals.

For people with this personality type, one of the great rewards of personal growth is becoming more effective – not just for their own sake, but for others as well. When Defenders nurture themselves, they enhance their ability to nurture and uplift others. Contented Defenders carry with them a bubble of happiness and goodwill that encompasses the people around them.

In these pages, we've outlined how Defenders can work on their growth and development in multiple areas of their lives. Our hope is that these insights and strategies equip Defenders to balance their instinct to care for other people with enough self-care to maintain their energy and equanimity – enabling them to show up both for others and for themselves throughout the courses of their lives.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you direct your personal growth journey? Explore our Personal Growth Tools and Assessments.
- Looking to enhance your academic or professional life? Check out the *Defender Guide to Careers*.
- Feeling adrift when it comes to your romantic relationships, friendships, or relationships with your children? Our *Defender Guide to Relationships* may be just what you need.

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